

HONOR IN THE SANCTUARY

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DEFINITION OF THE SANCTUARY

A sanctuary is a holy place set apart by God for worship, sacrifice, and communion between God and human beings. The word sanctuary comes from the meaning holy or sacred. In the Bible, the sanctuary was a physical structure designed by God Himself, where His presence dwelt among His people.

According to Scripture, God instructed Moses: “Let them make Me a sanctuary, that I may dwell among them.” This shows that the sanctuary was not built by human ideas but by divine instruction. Every detail of the sanctuary—its structure, furniture, colors, services, and priestly duties—had spiritual meaning and required honor, obedience, and reverence.

INTRODUCTION

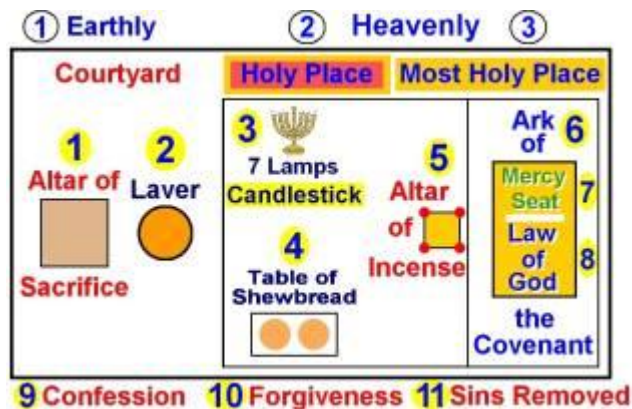
Honor in the sanctuary is understood by studying how God designed the sanctuary and how it was used. The sanctuary revealed God’s holiness, His plan of salvation, and the proper way humans should approach Him. Respect for the sanctuary was shown through correct worship, careful obedience, and reverent priestly service.

The sanctuary was divided into three main sections, each representing a deeper level of closeness to God:

1. The Courtyard

2. The Holy Place

3. The Most Holy Place (Holy of Holies)



THE STRUCTURE OF THE SANCTUARY

The sanctuary was designed by God to teach how sin is dealt with and how sinners are forgiven. Each section showed a stage in God's plan of salvation. Forgiveness was not random; it followed a clear, sacred process involving confession, sacrifice, blood, and priestly mediation.

The sanctuary had three main places:



1. The Courtyard

2. The Holy Place

3. The Most Holy Place

1. THE COURTYARD: CONFESSION AND FORGIVENESS OF SINS

What Happened in the Courtyard

The courtyard was where sin was first dealt with. A sinner who had committed a sin brought an animal (such as a lamb, goat, or bull) to the altar of burnt offering.

Process of Forgiveness in the Courtyard

1. The sinner placed his hands on the head of the animal.
2. He confessed his sins verbally.
3. By this act, the sins were symbolically transferred from the sinner to the animal.
4. The animal was then killed, and its blood was shed.

Role of Blood

Blood represented life.

The shedding of blood showed that sin leads to death.

God accepted the blood as a substitute for the sinner's life.

Altar of Burnt Offering

Sacrifices were burned on the altar.

This showed complete surrender and repentance.

Meaning

In the courtyard, God forgave sins through substitution. The sinner was forgiven because an innocent life died in his place. This teaches justification by faith.

The Laver

Before entering the Holy Place, the priest washed at the laver.

Meaning: Though forgiven, the priest had to be clean. This taught that those forgiven must also live purified lives.

2. THE HOLY PLACE: DAILY MINISTRY AND CONTINUED FORGIVENESS

What Happened in the Holy Place

The Holy Place was where daily priestly ministry took place. This is where sins, already forgiven in the courtyard, were symbolically recorded and dealt with through daily services.

Daily Ministry of the Priest

The priest entered the Holy Place every day to minister on behalf of the people.

a) Altar of Incense

Incense was burned morning and evening.

Represented prayers of the people.

Meaning: Forgiven sinners continued to rely on God through prayer.

b) Golden Lampstand

Gave light continually.

Meaning: God's presence and guidance were constant in the life of the forgiven believer.

c) Table of Showbread

Bread replaced every Sabbath.

Meaning: God sustained His forgiven people spiritually.

Blood in the Holy Place

In some sacrifices, blood was taken into the Holy Place.

This showed that sin, though forgiven, was symbolically transferred into the sanctuary.

Meaning of the Holy Place

The Holy Place represents sanctification—daily forgiveness, growth, obedience, prayer, and dependence on God.

3. THE MOST HOLY PLACE: FINAL JUDGMENT AND COMPLETE CLEANSING

What Happened in the Most Holy Place

The Most Holy Place was entered only once a year on the Day of Atonement.

Day of Atonement

The High Priest entered with blood.

He made atonement for the sanctuary and the people.

This cleansed the sanctuary from accumulated sins.

The Ark of the Covenant

Contained the Ten Commandments.

The Mercy Seat covered the Ark.

Meaning of Forgiveness Here

God judged sin according to His law.

Mercy was provided through the blood sprinkled on the Mercy Seat.

This showed that forgiveness is complete only when sin is fully removed.

Meaning of the Most Holy Place

This represents judgment, final atonement, and restoration.

HOW GOD FORGAVE SINS THROUGH THE SANCTUARY

God forgave sins through a clear process:

1. Confession of sin by the sinner
2. Death of a substitute
3. Blood applied by the priest
4. Daily mediation
5. Final cleansing on the Day of Atonement

This system taught that:

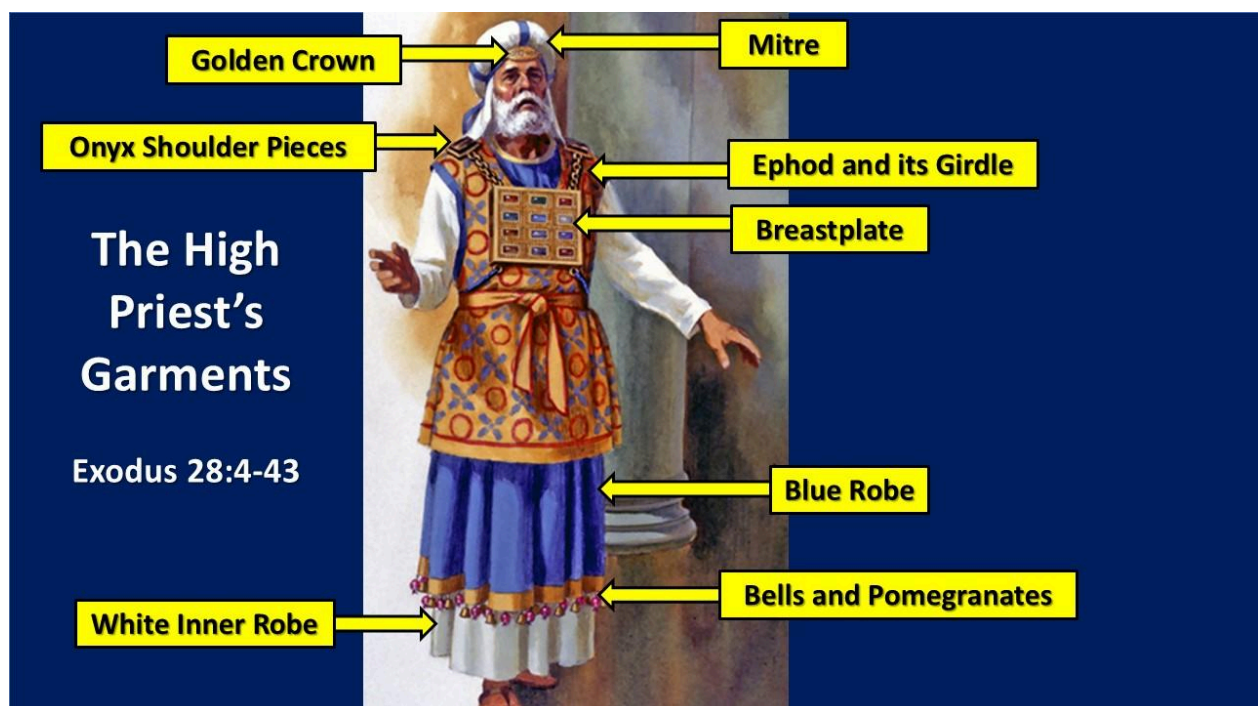
God is merciful

Sin is serious

Forgiveness requires repentance and faith

God removes sin completely

PRIESTLY GARMENTS AND THEIR MEANING



The priestly garments were designed by God and symbolized purity, authority, and holiness.

Colors and Their Meanings

Blue: Heaven, obedience, God's law

Purple: Royalty and kingship

Scarlet (Red): Blood, sacrifice, redemption

White Linen: Righteousness and purity

Gold: Divinity, holiness, glory

Garments of the High Priest

Ephod

Breastplate with twelve stones

Robe with bells and pomegranates

Turban with gold plate inscribed "Holiness to the Lord"

THE VEIL

Separated the Holy Place from the Most Holy Place

Symbolized separation caused by sin

Represented restricted access to God

HONOR IN THE SANCTUARY

Honor in the sanctuary was demonstrated by:

Obedience to God's instructions

Proper priestly conduct

Reverence for sacred spaces

Respect for God's presence

Disrespect resulted in severe consequences, emphasizing the seriousness of holiness.

SPIRITUAL LESSONS FROM THE SANCTUARY

God desires to dwell with humanity

Salvation follows a divine order

Worship requires reverence and obedience

God is both merciful and just

CONCLUSION

The sanctuary teaches powerful lessons about God's holiness, salvation, and proper worship. Understanding the courtyard, Holy Place, Most Holy Place, priestly ministry, and sacred symbols reveals the importance of honoring God in all aspects of worship and life.

REVIEW QUESTIONS

1. Define the term sanctuary.
2. State the purpose of the sanctuary according to the Bible.
3. Name the three main parts of the sanctuary.
4. Describe the courtyard and list the furniture found in it.
5. Explain the spiritual meaning of the altar of burnt offering.
6. What was the purpose of the laver?
7. Who was allowed to enter the Holy Place?

8. List the furniture found in the Holy Place and state their meanings.
9. How many times did the priest minister in the Holy Place?
10. Describe the Most Holy Place.
11. What item was found in the Most Holy Place and what did it contain?
12. Who was allowed to enter the Most Holy Place and how often?
13. What was the Day of Atonement?
14. List the main colors of the priestly garments.
15. Explain the meaning of any three colors used in the priestly garments.
16. What was written on the high priest's turban and what did it mean?
17. Explain the meaning of the veil in the sanctuary.
18. What lessons can Christians learn from the sanctuary today?
19. Explain how honor was shown in the sanctuary.
20. Why is the study of the sanctuary important to believers?